

ZHIYUAN LAI

Undergraduate at Peking University

Research interests include **digital inequality** and **inclusive technology**

Tel: +86-18 810 811 227 E-mail: lzy1122@stu.pku.edu.cn Website: <http://itsleol.github.io>

EDUCATION

Peking University, Beijing, China

B.M. in Information Management and Information Systems

Sep 2023 — June 2027 (expected)

B.A. in Sociology (Double Major)

Sep 2025 — June 2027 (expected)

GPA: 3.71/4.00 (Top 10%)

National Tsing Hua University, Hsinchu, Taiwan

Visiting Student

Jun 2025 — Aug 2025

Conducted a cross-cultural study on Taiwanese public attitudes toward generative AI under the supervision of Prof. Tzu-Hua Wang.

PUBLICATION

Tang, Y. & **Lai, Z.** (Under Review) Empowering LGBTQIA+ identity formation in China through LLM-based chatbots. *Journal of Information Science*.

Lai, Z., & Tang, Y. (2026). Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use. *Information Research: an International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 328–344.
<https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64121>.

Chen, N., **Lai, Z.**, Liu, Y., Li, J., Wang, R., & Yan, P. (2026). See, trust, and interact: how AI disclosure shapes high school students' trust. *Information Research: an International Electronic Journal*, 31(iConf), 1099–1145. <https://doi.org/10.47989/ir31iConf64165>.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Lai, Z., & Tang, Y. (2026, March).

Beyond or within the binary? Constructing gendered meanings in generative AI use.

Paper presented at the iConference 2026, Edinburgh, Scotland, UK.

Lai, Z. (2025, July).

Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms.

Paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2025, Chengdu, China.

Lai, Z. (2026, July).

Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among HIV-Positive Individuals.

Paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Chinese Sociological Association 2026, Xi'an, China.

Lai, Z. (2026).

Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among HIV-Positive Individuals.

Paper presented at the 19th National Doctoral Forum in Library and Information Science.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

AI & Society Research Group, Research Assistant

May 2024 - Present

Advisor: Dr. Pu Yan

- National Natural Science Foundation project “A Study on the Influencing Factors and Mechanisms of the Algorithmic Divide”, conducting literature reviews and quantitative data analysis.

- Support a Beijing Social Science Foundation project “A Study on Algorithm Literacy among Beijing Citizens” by refining survey designs and analyzing data.

Undergraduate Research Program, Leader

May 2024 - Oct 2025

Public Trust and Attitudes toward Generative AI in China

Advisor: Dr. Pu Yan

(Selected as Excellent Undergraduate Research Project)

- Led a multi-stage, mixed-methods study to address the gap in localized AI trust measurement.
- Developed and validated a GenAI Trust Scale for Chinese through two large-scale surveys.
- Designed and executed a field experiment using a Tobii eye-tracker to determine the causal impact of different AI disclosure strategies on user trust.
- Analyzed eye-tracking and survey data using R, discovering that simple AI labels enhance trust in conversational contexts but decrease it in news consumption.
- Conducted a related cross-cultural study on Taiwanese public attitudes at National Tsing Hua University (Summer 2025, advised by Prof. Tzu-Hua Wang).

SELECTED RESEARCH PROJECTS

Peking University Challenge Cup Science Competition, 33rd

Nov 2024 - Mar 2025

Rural Windows on Screens: Self-Presentation and Social Interaction of Middle-Aged and Elderly Women on Short-Video Platforms

Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- First Prize, University Level. Presented at the 2025 Chinese Sociological Association Annual Conference.
- Spearheaded a mixed-methods project combining ethnographic fieldwork in rural Hebei Province with computational social science methods.
- Independently scraped and analyzed public comment data from Douyin and Kuaishou using Python (BERTopic) to model user interaction and self-presentation.
- Authored the final report, which framed short-video use as a flexible resistance to social marginalization and a tool for community building.

Peking University Challenge Cup Science Competition, 34th

Nov 2025 - Mar 2026

Lives Under Stigma: Biographical Disruption, Continuation, and Reconstruction among HIV-Positive Individuals – Information Practices as a Survival Strategy

Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Third Prize. Presented at the 2026 Chinese Sociological Association Annual Conference.
- Conducted multi-site fieldwork at Beijing Ditan Hospital and the Beijing Red Ribbon Home, combining semi-structured in-depth interviews, participant observation, and online ethnography.
- Conceptualized HIV diagnosis as an “information event”, a node where information transmission and biographical disruption are inseparable, to bridge life course theory, medical sociology, and information behavior research.
- Identified dimensions of biographical disruption and reconstruction mechanisms. Developed a typology of information practices, information avoidance, information control, and information shaping, as core survival strategies that mediate between disruption and reconstruction.

Alienation in Parent-Child Relationships Among Youth in the Context of Social Acceleration Feb 2025 - June 2025

Advisor: Dr. Xingkun Liang

- Independently designed and executed an empirical analysis using China Family Panel Studies data to investigate kin-estrangement.
- Utilized Stata for OLS regression, mediation, and moderation models, identifying that increased screen time significantly correlated with reduced parent-child intimacy.

HONORS & AWARDS

2023-2024 Award for Academic Excellence, National Encouragement Scholarship
2024-2025 Merit Student, National Encouragement Scholarship, The Second Prize of Peking University Scholarship

SKILLS

Languages	English (TOEFL: 104), Chinese (native), Hakka (native)
Programming	Python, SQL, JavaScript, HTML, CSS
Quantitative Analysis	R, Stata, SPSS
Qualitative Analysis	NVivo